

See also: The Cruelty to Animals Act 146–147 ■ The “Vivisection Act” 163 ■ The World Network of Biosphere Reserves 270–271 ■ The Kyoto Protocol 305

CITES and international conservation

By the mid-20th century, the world began to recognize that the international trade in wild animals and plants was driving some species to extinction, exploited for food, medicine, or other purposes. In 1963, the International Union for the Conservation of Nature (IUCN), which monitors global diversity, began work on an international agreement to restrict this trade. These efforts came to fruition in Washington, DC, in 1973 with CITES, the Convention

on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora. CITES regulates or bans international trade in species under threat and is now one of the cornerstones of international conservation. CITES currently has 183 signatory countries and regulates trade in more than 5,000 animal and 30,000 plant species. The parties to the Convention meet regularly and develop plans to protect endangered plants and animals from commercial exploitation.

species in danger of worldwide extinction by prohibiting their importation and subsequent sale in the US. Inspired by regulations adopted by the 1973 Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES), the groundbreaking Endangered Species Act (ESA) went even further to protect the natural heritage of the US.

Coordinated efforts

The ESA allows individuals and organizations to petition to have a species listed as endangered or threatened. There is then a rigorous scientific evaluation and public review before a final decision is made to put the species on the list. If a species is listed, critical habitat areas are given special protection, and a Species Recovery Plan is put in place, outlining how the numbers of the endangered species will be increased.

Populations are monitored over time to see whether a species has recovered enough to be removed from the list. This long-

term commitment is a key part of the Act. Most wildlife experts consider the ESA a huge success in preventing extinctions. It is credited with the comeback of several species—including the American bald eagle, the California condor, and the grizzly bear—and it set a global standard for protection of endangered species.

In 2019, in a bid to satisfy the demands of commercial interests, President Trump’s administration

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The ESA is the strongest and most effective tool we have to repair the environmental harm that is causing a species to decline.

Norm Dicks

US congressman (1977–2013)

made revisions to the ESA that weakened it significantly. One of the proposed revisions is to restrict the protected critical habitat to the area the endangered species now survives in rather than the area it would inhabit if it recovered. With the climate crisis and other environmental threats accelerating species loss at an alarming rate, the changes to the ESA defy calls for stronger, not weaker, protection. ■

Bird species threatened under the ESA

